

Chapter 16

On the way back to the hotel, Yin Lingzhu kept thinking about Yan Si's words: "I like you."

She shamefully discovered that her heart was beating uncontrollably.

Lying in bed, she covered her eyes with her hand.

What right did Yan Si have to say she liked her?

This past year, Yan Si had given her endless waiting and countless wounds.

Yin Lingzhu recalled the scene when she first met Yan Si.

The hospital's fluorescent lights were blindingly bright. Yan Si pushed the door open and entered, opening not just the ward door, but also the door to Yin Lingzhu's heart.

Light slanted down from above her, tracing along her body's silhouette, outlining a sacred glow around her.

In that moment, the Yan Si that Yin Lingzhu saw seemed otherworldly.

Yin Lingzhu shook her head, trying to erase this image.

She forced herself not to think about Yan Si.

Yan Si saying she liked her was simply unbelievable.

The corners of Yin Lingzhu's eyes reddened. Of course she hoped Yan Si could like her.

But Yan Si's behavior this past year made her understand how unrealistic this was.

Yan Si was even stingy with giving her the smiles she showed to the public.

What right did Yan Si have to say she liked her?

At this moment, Yin Lingzhu found Yan Si's words utterly ridiculous.

Her fingertips touched the corner of her eyes, feeling her own tears.

Including the year since coming to this world, she had lived for 25 years total and had never been so humble.

Perhaps they should never have met in the first place.

Yan Si was only using her - why did she persist in her delusion?

Yin Lingzhu wiped the tears from the corners of her eyes, mocking herself for being so foolish.

Yin Lingzhu pulled the covers over herself, gradually becoming drowsy and falling asleep.

On the other side, Yan Si absent-mindedly returned to apartment 2316¹.

This apartment was in the city center and had excellent security.

Sometimes when filming, if she didn't want to stay at a hotel, she would come to this apartment.

But ever since she had given the apartment to Yin Lingzhu, she could count on one hand the number of times she had come here.

Yan Si used her pale fingertips to feel along the wall, locating the position before pressing the switch.

With her movement, the pitch-black apartment instantly lit up.

Light scattered everywhere, covering every corner.

Yan Si hadn't put effort into decorating the room; the living room lights were blindingly white.

Yan Si sat on the sofa, her gaze sweeping inch by inch over every piece of furniture.

The room had been kept very tidy by Yin Lingzhu, without a trace of any changes.

There was also no sign of life.

She remembered Yin Lingzhu had told her she wanted to redecorate the room.

But she was afraid Yin Lingzhu would discover the surveillance she had hidden in this apartment, so she hadn't agreed.

Yan Si took out the divorce agreement. She had never actually thought Yin Lingzhu would sign it.

Her fingers traced over the place where Yin Lingzhu had written her name.

Then, she steeled her heart and frantically tore up the divorce agreement, the pieces falling like snowflakes throughout the room.

Yan Si's eyes showed obsession - as long as she didn't agree, they wouldn't be considered divorced.

What Yin Lingzhu didn't know was that when Yin Lingzhu fell in love with Yan Si at first sight, Yan Si had also fallen for Yin Lingzhu at first sight.

On the way to the hospital, Yan Si had felt very impatient.

But when she pushed open the ward door and noticed the person lying on the bed, her heart also jumped violently.

When their eyes met, she could clearly see Yin Lingzhu's undisguised love.

It was so direct that it made Yan Si want to escape.

Having reached the position of movie queen, Yan Si had held fan meetings and seen fans who were crazy about her.

But none of those fans' gazes had been like Yin Lingzhu's, making her want to hide.

Like someone who had lived in darkness for too long accidentally seeing sunlight - yearning yet timid.

Yin Lingzhu's gaze was like that ray of sunlight to Yan Si.

Yan Si couldn't quite handle it.

So she put on her most practiced smile and extended her hand to Yin Lingzhu.

Yan Si saw Yin Lingzhu's face and neck turn completely red.

The moment she was marked² by Yin Lingzhu, Yan Si felt pain at the back of her neck.

But more than the insignificant pain was the satisfaction that came from deep in her heart.

She had actually genuinely considered living well with Yin Lingzhu.

She had already planned it out - first let Yin Lingzhu live in the apartment for a while, finish filming the current drama, then bring Yin Lingzhu back to the ancestral home to meet her mother.

But that day while filming, she discovered someone whose phone contained a photo of Yin Lingzhu with the phone's owner.

In the photo, Yin Lingzhu was intimately embracing the person next to her with a brilliant smile.

She knew that person - they had met at a birthday banquet where she had attended in place of her father.

At that time, Yan Si had already made up her mind to compete for the family inheritance, so she tried to make connections with influential people at various occasions.

Yan Si had exchanged business cards with her.

Ming Qingyun³.

After it ended, Yan Si had investigated Ming Qingyun's background. It truly fit the saying "from rags to riches, rising step by step."

For the first time on set, Yan Si had initiated conversation with someone else.

She asked Ming Qingyun if she was a fan of Yin Lingzhu.

She knew Yin Lingzhu was with an entertainment company.

Ming Qingyun had invested in this drama and was here for inspection today, wearing a proper black suit with a serious expression.

When she heard Yan Si's question, she shook her head.

"No, she's my girlfriend."

When she said this, a smile appeared on her face.

Hearing this answer, Yan Si didn't know how to respond. She nodded stiffly, nearly unable to maintain her smile.

She made small talk for a few sentences, then found an excuse to return to her dressing room.

After entering the room, Yan Si locked the door behind her.

Looking at herself through the mirror, she could see the inferiority hidden deep in her eyes.

That night, she had originally planned to ask Yin Lingzhu about the photo she had seen during the day and about the girlfriend situation.

But Yan Si saw Yin Lingzhu coming out of the neighbor's room with her clothes half on.

Yan Si didn't know how to bring up the question with Yin Lingzhu.

The next day.

Yin Lingzhu, who had just woken up, touched her eyes - they were swollen again. She had to apply a wet towel to her eyes.

She thought helplessly that recently, every time she encountered Yan Si, she ended up crying.

When Yin Lingzhu arrived at the company, she found someone was already in the studio.

She took out her phone to check the time - 7:30 AM.

She had thought she would be the first one there, but apparently there were more diligent people.

"Good morning, Captain." Wan Miaoyin greeted her with a smile.

Yin Lingzhu politely returned the greeting.

Wan Miaoyin kept trying to find topics to talk about, but because Yin Lingzhu's mind was on lyric distribution issues, her responses were somewhat perfunctory.

After Kong Murui arrived, all three were present.

After discussion, they determined the distribution of lyrics, and the three began targeted practice.

In the blink of an eye, it was time for the competition.

Since most participants were unknowns⁴, the three had no problem advancing to the finals.

The show emphasized authenticity - participants and audience learned news at the same time.

Yin Lingzhu heard that a special guest judge had come but didn't pay much attention.

When Yin Lingzhu stepped onto the stage, she bowed toward the judges' panel.

When she straightened up and saw Yan Si sitting in the special guest judge's seat, she was somewhat shocked.

What was a movie queen like Yan Si doing on a singing show?

Footnotes:

¹ **Apartment 2316:** The specific apartment number indicates this is likely a high-end residential building where wealthy people like Yan Si would own property.

² **Marked:** In omegaverse fiction, this refers to the process where an Alpha bites an Omega's scent gland (usually on the neck) to form a deeper bond, often permanent in nature.

³ **Ming Qingyun** (明青雲): A name that means "bright blue clouds," suggesting someone with lofty aspirations. This character appears to be a successful businesswoman who was Yin Lingzhu's previous romantic interest.

⁴ **Unknowns** (素人): In Chinese entertainment terminology, this refers to regular people who are not professional entertainers or celebrities - ordinary individuals rather than trained performers.